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LeBron James: NBA All-Time Scoring Leader, Olympic Gold Medalist, and Barbie Doll?

On April 14, toy store shelves were packed with the new “Kenbassador” dolls. According to Barbie’s manufacturing company, Mattel, this line of figures celebrates “influential male figures creating positive change in the world and their communities.” LeBron James was the first doll in the series.

“I’d pay a million dollars for it. Seventy-five dollars is a steal, in my opinion,” said Nigel Swinson, a LeBron James fan and first-year student.

The LeBron James doll sold for \$75 across stores such as Target and Walmart. Theater first-year Cassidey Fralin says the cost of the figurine is “unfair.”

“I’m assuming the reason it’s priced so high is because it’s meant to act as a collectible, but I feel like that kind of defeats the purpose,” said Fralin. “The appeal of Barbie is that you’re getting something that you can play with and possibly get another and share, and I think that price range is a bit unfair to lots of families.”

Fourth-year student Dhruv Patel says the toy is comical, referencing James' surge on his TikTok, "For You" page.

"It's kind of funny," said Patel. "LeBron's very meme-able and, especially recently—at least on my 'For You' page—there's been a lot of LeBron memes."

Weinberg first-year Saniya Newman says that Barbie is often correlated with a demographic of young girls, and this Barbie-LeBron James collaboration will start to stray away from that notion.

"It's progressive, where I feel like maybe it's encouraging boys to play with Barbie more, just because Barbie is seen more as a girl thing," said Newman. "Men should have the freedom like girls to play with either toy without gender norms. So this could be a step into the future."

Theater first-year Mariah Waters grew up with Barbie dolls and says the figurine could inspire boys like her brother to play with the toys.

"If I was like, 'brother, come play barbies with me,' he'd be like, 'okay, I can play Barbie because look, now I have a LeBron Barbie,'" Waters said.

Weinberg fourth-year Namish Kaistha says the James doll is a great collaboration for the toy line, taking Barbie away from the feminine lifestyle sector and experimenting with athletics.

“This is great for representation,” said Kaistha. “This is great for Barbie to break into the market—like the youth basketball market. It's different than their typical thing.”

The LeBron James Kenbassador has since been sold out and is on resale websites like eBay for more than \$100.

“I am not surprised that it’s sold out,” said first-year Tamyrha Dunoc. “I know he has a very loyal fan base and following, so kids and adults probably want to collect this.”

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Sources:

- Cassidey Fralin, first-year student, Theatre major, Northwestern University, age 19, Los Angeles, California, (424) 744-0660, CassideyFralin2028@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 22, 2025.
- Mariah Waters, first-year student, Theatre major, Northwestern University, Ashburn, Virginia, (407) 902-9074 , MariahWaters2028@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 22, 2025.
- Saniya Newman, first-year student, Psychology major, Northwestern University, Joliet, Illinois, (815) 585-5474, SaniyaNewman2028@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 22, 2025.
- Dhruv Patel, fourth-year student, Biology major, Northwestern University, Chicago, Illinois, DhruvPatel2025@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 21, 2025.
- Namish Kaistha, fourth-year student, Economics and Computer Science major, Northwestern University, Chicago, Illinois, (630) 877-0378, NamishKaistha2025@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 21, 2025.
- Tamyrha Dunac, first-year student, Theatre major, Northwestern University, Amityville, New York, (917) 780-9349, TamyrhaDunac2028@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 21, 2025.

- Adam Freshley, first-year student, Economics and Political Science major, Northwestern University, La Mesa, California, adamfreshly2028@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 21, 2025.
- Nigel Swinson, first-year student, Voice and Opera major, Northwestern University, New York, New York, (917) 279-1392, NigelSwinson2028@u.northwestern.edu , interview conducted in person on April 21, 2025.